

MODULE 32 / 40

Steller's Jay

*Cyanocitta stelleri***QUICK STATS**

Length	11.8 – 13.4 in (30 – 34 cm)
Wingspan	17.3 in (44 cm)
Weight	3.5 – 4.9 oz (100 – 140 g)
Lifespan	Up to 16 years (avg. 6 in wild)

PRESENTATION

Steller's Jay is the western counterpart of the Blue Jay — a large, crested jay of western coniferous forests whose dramatic two-toned plumage, sooty black in front and deep cobalt blue behind, makes it one of the most striking birds at western feeders. Named after the German naturalist Georg Wilhelm Steller, who collected the first specimen in Alaska in 1741, it is the only crested jay found west of the Rocky Mountains. Bold, raucous, and highly intelligent, it is a dominant presence at feeders and campsites throughout the mountains and forests of the Pacific states, British Columbia, and the Rocky Mountain region.

HABITAT & RANGE

Steller's Jay is found year-round from southern Alaska south through British Columbia and the Pacific states to Central America, and east through the Rocky Mountains. It is a bird of coniferous and mixed forests, particularly favoring mature pine, fir, and spruce forests at mid to high elevations. In winter it descends to lower elevations and readily visits suburban feeders and campgrounds. It is a permanent resident throughout most of its range, though montane populations make seasonal elevational movements.

DIET & FEEDING

- Acorns and pine seeds — the core of the natural diet, cached for winter
- Black-oil sunflower seeds and peanuts at feeders
- Suet cakes and corn
- Insects, beetles, and grasshoppers in summer
- Eggs and nestlings of other birds — an opportunistic predator
- Berries, small fruits, and carrion scavenged from campsites

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Steller's Jays are bold, assertive, and highly intelligent birds that quickly learn to associate humans with food. They are among the most dominant species at western feeders, displacing smaller birds with ease. Like other corvids, they are avid food cachers — storing acorns, pine seeds, and sunflower seeds in the ground and in bark crevices, relocating caches with remarkable accuracy weeks or months later. They are also accomplished mimics, frequently imitating the calls of Red-tailed Hawks, Osprey, and other raptors — possibly to frighten other birds away from food sources. Outside the breeding season they often gather in loose groups.

NESTING & BREEDING

Steller's Jays build large, bulky cup nests of sticks, leaves, and mud in the fork of a conifer, typically 10–40 feet above the ground. Both parents build the nest. Clutches of 3–5 pale green or blue eggs with dark spots are incubated primarily by the female for 16–18 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 17–19 days. One brood per season. Pairs mate for life and maintain year-round territories.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

Steller's Jay is one of the most vocal birds in western forests, producing a wide array of harsh, loud calls. The most common is a repeated "shook-shook-shook" or "shek-shek-shek" — a penetrating series that carries through dense forest. It also gives a harsh "waaaah" alarm and mimics the calls of Red-tailed Hawks, Golden Eagles, and other species with impressive accuracy. Soft, gurgling notes are used between mated pairs.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining slightly
----------------	---------------	-------------------	--------------------

The Steller's Jay population is estimated at 2.8 million individuals and has shown modest declines linked to habitat loss in old-growth coniferous forests and the effects of climate change on montane ecosystems. It is highly dependent on mature forest with large nut-producing trees. Retaining old-growth conifers and offering supplemental food at western feeders support local populations.

FEEDER TIPS

- Whole peanuts and sunflower seeds on a large platform feeder work best
- Steller's Jays are dominant — place feeders for smaller birds out of sight
- They cache food — expect them to carry multiple seeds or nuts at once
- Suet in a cage near conifers is readily taken in winter
- They are bold — will approach within feet of a patient, still observer

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Head, crest & back (front)	Sooty black
Body & wings	Deep cobalt blue
Fine wing barring	Pale blue — visible up close
Crest	Tall, prominent, black
Underparts	Dark blue — not as bright as back
Bill & legs	Black

COLOR ME!

Steller's Jay • *Cyanocitta stelleri* • Module 32

